Unit 2 — Growing Up

Track G+M · Klasse 7 · Niveau G/M

Learning objectives I

- *I can describe how something about me has changed since primary school using "used to".*
- *I can read a short narrative about a peer's growing pains and identify three concrete changes the writer notices.*
- *I can write a short text (60–120 words depending on Niveau) comparing then and now using comparatives and "used to".*

Lead-in I

Ben opens his old jacket on a hanger in the hallway. It looks shorter than he remembers. He puts it on, just to check, and the sleeves stop above his wrists like two embarrassed flags. Last winter, the same jacket was a kind of cave. He used to push his hands deep into the pockets and forget about the cold. Now the pockets sit somewhere near his ribs, like two extra pencil cases that have lost their place. Aisha is standing in the doorway with her bag on her shoulder. She looks at the jacket and says, ”Did the jacket shrink?” Ben says, ”No. I think *I* grew.” Ms. Reyes walks past and nods. ”Welcome to seventh year,” she says. ”Half of you will need new shoes by Christmas.”

Vocabulary I

- short (1 syll.)
- ending -y
- 2+ syll.
- irregular

Reading I

Reading text — *Ben's Jacket*

When Ben turned twelve, he stopped fitting his old jacket. The sleeves used to cover his hands; now they ended above his wrists. His mother laughed and said, "I didn't see this coming." The strange thing was that nothing else in the house had changed: the kitchen table, the loud fridge, the cat asleep on the radiator. Only Ben was different. He used to like the jacket because the pockets were enormous. He still liked the pockets. But now they sat too high on his ribs to be useful.

Aisha said the same thing happened to her shoes. They used to feel like boats. Now they felt like sleeping bags two sizes too small. "Maybe we should swap," Ben said. "I'll take your old shoes;

Reading II

you take my old jacket.” Aisha frowned. ”We are not the same shape, Ben.”
She was right. They never were.
Quick comprehension check (oral, no points):

- What changed about Ben?
- What did **not** change in the house?
- Why does Aisha say ”We are not the same shape”?

Reading III

Language focus — *used to* and comparatives
Used to + base verb describes a habit or state in the past that is no longer true.

- *The sleeves used to cover his hands.* — they did, but not now.
- *Aisha used to wear short hair.* — she doesn't anymore.
- *Negative: He didn't use to like maths.* (Note: no *-d* on *use* in negatives and questions.)
- *Question: Did you use to play the recorder in primary school?*

Reading IV

Comparatives describe how two things or two times differ.

Adjective type	Comparative	Example
short (1 syll.) ending *-y*	+ *-er* *-ier*	tall → taller happy → happier

Adjective type	Comparative	Example
2+ syll. irregular	*more* + adj. —	difficult → more difficult good → better; bad → worse; far → farther/further

Reading V

Spelling traps: *big → bigger* (double consonant), *nice → nicer* (drop final *e*), *easy → easier* (*y → i*). *Used to* is **not** the same as *to be used to* + *-ing* (*"I'm used to early mornings"* = I am accustomed to). Keep them apart. We use only the past-habit *used to* in this Unit.

Practise I

Niveau G — controlled
A. Match the past habit to the present truth.

Past (*used to*)	**Present**
1. Ben used to fit his old jacket.	a. Now they end above his wrists.
2. The sleeves used to cover his hands.	b. Now Ben’s bedroom is full of books.

Past (*used to*)	**Present**
3. Ben’s bedroom used to be full of toys.	c. Now it is too short.
4. Aisha used to wear small shoes.	d. Now her shoes feel small.

Practise II

B. Comparative gap-fill.

5. This year, Aisha is _____ (tall) than her cousin.
6. Ben's voice is _____ (deep) than last year.
7. The walk to school feels _____ (short) on sunny days.

Niveau M — productive
C. Build a sentence with *used to*.

8. Ben / fit / his old jacket → ___

Practise III

9. Aisha / have / short hair → ___
10. Ms. Reyes / live / in a different city → ___

D. Comparatives — finish the sentence with your own words.

11. My handwriting is _____ now than it was in Klasse 5.
12. The school cafeteria is _____ at lunch than at breakfast.
13. My favourite subject is _____ this year than it was last year.

Your turn I

Writing task — *Then and Now*. Write a short personal text comparing yourself in primary school with yourself now. Use *used to* at least twice and at least two comparatives.
You may write about:

- a habit (food, sport, hobby),
- something you owned (a toy, a backpack, a piece of clothing),
- a friendship,
- a place you used to spend time in.

Your turn II

Niveau G — 60–80 words, three sentences with *used to* and two comparatives.
Niveau M — 100–120 words, four sentences with *used to* and three comparatives.

Sample student response (Niveau M, 116 words)
When I was in primary school, I used to ride my bike to the bakery every Saturday morning. I used to buy two pretzels: one for me and one for my brother, who is now taller than me. The bakery was closer to our old house, so the trip used to be shorter. Now we live further away and the bakery feels like a serious expedition. My bike is also smaller than it used to feel — I think the bike has stayed the same and I have grown. The pretzels are still warm and salty, though, and that part is better than ever. Some things are worth a longer ride.

Your turn III

Strong moves: a small concrete subject (bakery + pretzel), *used to* in three places, three comparatives (*taller*, *shorter*, *smaller*, *better*), and a closing line that holds the piece together. Improve by varying connectives (”though”, ”so”, ”but”) rather than only ”and”.

Reflect I

- I can talk about a past habit using *used to*.
- I can read a short narrative and pick out three changes the writer notices.
- I can write a short comparing-text with *used to* and at least two comparatives.

Further reading / listening I

- BBC Learning English — *6 Minute Grammar: Used to*. https://www.bbc.co.uk/learningenglish/english/features/6-minute-grammar
- Roald Dahl — *Boy: Tales of Childhood* (extract). A model of remembering childhood with concrete detail and gentle humour. https://www.roalddahl.com
- BBC Bitesize — *Comparative and superlative adjectives*. https://www.bbc.co.uk/bitesize/topics/zhfygdm